incorporated neighbouring territories in order to create buffer states to ensure security. Modern India has inherited both the belief in a civilizational sphere of influence and in the idea that geographic neighbours are critical to a state's security against invasion, irredentism and disintegration. For the makers of India's foreign policy, the Indian subcontinent is one entity, the states neighbouring India are important for India's security and India's immediate area of interest extends from the Middle East to South-East Asia.

India's inheritance in the sphere of philosophy and thought has added to the world view shaped by geography and security compulsions. Writing in the 1960s, American scholar on South Asia Norman Palmer noted, 'Almost every aspect of foreign as well as of domestic policy in India seems to be rooted in tradition and to have philosophical underpinnings.'[3] The invoking of tradition varies depending on the personality of contemporary India's current leader. For example, Nehru cited history frequently in his speeches whereas some of his successors did not. Modi's deference to tradition comes in the form of leading mass yoga sessions on International Yoga Day more than in historic references in speeches. There is, however, a continuous trend of turning to India's heritage both to generate national pride and to explain contemporary policies.



India's five millennia as a civilizational entity has always involved engagement with the outside world. Right from the earliest times, Indian kingdoms and empires maintained ties with other countries and regions. There is evidence of diplomatic relations between ancient Indian kingdoms and those in China, Rome, Greece, Egypt and Mesopotamia. The Hindu and Buddhist religions that arose in India expanded beyond the subcontinent, providing evidence of India's links beyond its shores and mountains. Some South-East Asian empires were even led by dynasties which practised